

August 2026

Dear Howard,

I've spent a long time working in Lafayette and the surrounding hills, and homes along Reliez Valley Road and its quiet courts always get my attention - especially when they sit on nearly three-quarters of an acre with unobstructed views of Mount Diablo. When 15 Surmont Ct came to market, I noticed it right away: the lot position, the wrap-around deck, the pool and sports court, and those open wood beam ceilings on the main level tell a compelling story about how this home actually lives. When the listing came off the market after 62 days without a sale, I thought it was worth reaching out.

Sixty-two days is long enough for a pattern to form in buyers' minds, and the pattern here wasn't about the home - it was about how the home was presented. A property with this much going for it, at \$514 per square foot, sits well below what Lafayette buyers typically pay for something with a lot like this and a floor plan this flexible. That gap between the underlying value and the outcome usually points to a strategy problem: the right buyers weren't found, or the story that would have motivated them to schedule a showing was never clearly told.

I've put together a short analysis of what the listing history suggests and how I'd approach a relaunch differently. It's specific to 15 Surmont Ct - the views, the multi-level layout, the in-law suite, the outdoor amenities - not a generic overview of the Lafayette market. I think you'll find it useful whether you decide to work with me or not.

If you're already working with a real estate agent toward a new listing, please feel free to set this aside - no pressure at all. But if you're still weighing your options, I'd welcome a conversation.

With respect,

A handwritten signature in blue ink, appearing to read 'Ben Olsen', with a long horizontal line extending to the right.

Ben Olsen

REALTOR · BrightWork Realty Advocates
(925) 255-9727 · brightworkrealty.com
455 Moraga Road, Suite I · Moraga, CA 94556

The Path to Sold:

15 Surmont Ct

Lafayette, CA 94549

5.0 Beds · 4 Baths · 3,498 Sq Ft · Lafayette

The Blueprint for a Successful Sale

Prepared For: The Owners of 15 Surmont Ct

Presented By: Ben Olsen · BrightWork Realty Advocates

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A Multi-Level Reliez Valley Estate with Panoramic Views - and a Listing That Didn't Show It

15 Surmont Ct has the kind of physical profile that Lamorinda buyers search for and rarely find: a true 0.73-acre lot at the end of a private court, sweeping views of Mount Diablo, a flexible 3,498 square foot floor plan with a self-contained lower-level suite, and outdoor amenities - pool, sundeck, sports court, firepit - that would cost well over six figures to replicate. The open beam ceiling living room, wrap-around deck, and three fireplaces give the home a character that photographs well when shot correctly. This is a property that should have attracted serious buyer interest quickly.

The listing history tells a different story. After 62 days on the market, the home came off without a sale. At \$514 per square foot, it was priced well below the Lafayette benchmark for a home of this quality and lot size - so the issue wasn't an aggressive number. The issue was that the strategy never made a clear case for what the home offered at that price. The Mount Diablo views, the court location, the multi-generational layout, and the outdoor living package were all mentioned, but they weren't staged as the headline. Buyers comparing options need a reason to drive out to Surmont Ct. A description that buries the view and the lot in a list of features isn't that reason.

\$1,798,000

List Price

\$514/sqft

Price Per Sq. Ft.

None

HOA Fees

A relaunch needs to do one thing above all else: put the view, the lot, and the lifestyle front and center - visually and in every word of the listing - so that the buyers who would pay a premium for exactly this kind of property find it before they settle for something else.

MARKET FORENSICS: WHY IT DIDN'T SELL

Every expired listing has a story. Here's what the listing history tells us about what held this one back, and what a different strategy would have done.

Friction #1: 62 Days Created a Story the Home Didn't Deserve

Once a listing crosses the 45-day mark, buyer psychology shifts in a specific and predictable way. Buyers stop asking 'Is this a good home?' and start asking 'What's wrong with it?' At 62 days, that skepticism was fully in place for 15 Surmont Ct - and it had nothing to do with the home itself. A 0.73-acre lot with Mount Diablo views and a pool, priced at \$514 per square foot, is not a hard sell. It's a distribution and timing problem: the buyers who would have moved quickly on this home were never reached in a concentrated enough window to generate the momentum a property like this needed. More time on the same strategy doesn't fix that. A fresh start with a different approach does.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork uses geo-targeted digital campaigns to reach SF and East Bay buyers who are actively researching Lamorinda before they've committed to a neighborhood - putting 15 Surmont Ct in front of decision-makers while they're still forming their shortlist, not after they've already scheduled showings elsewhere.

Friction #2: The Visual Story of This Home Was Never Told

The open beam ceilings, the wrap-around deck overlooking Mount Diablo, the pool and sports court, and the court-end privacy are exactly the kind of assets that sell Lafayette homes at the top of the price range. But assets like these live or die on photography and media. Standard MLS angles - a wide shot of the living room, a flat exterior from the driveway - leave the panoramic view invisible and the setting unexplained. At \$1,798,000, buyers comparing this home to others in Lafayette needed to feel the lot, the view, and the outdoor package before they ever scheduled a showing. Without the right visual, a home like this reads as spacious but unremarkable. The character that justifies the number stayed hidden.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork's Sky Tour puts the lot, the court position, the view corridor toward Mount Diablo, and the outdoor amenities in context that no ground photograph can replicate - giving online buyers the full picture before they decide whether to make the drive.

Friction #3: The Listing Description Enumerated Features Instead of Building a Case

The listing description for 15 Surmont Ct ran through a long list of features - Dacor range, Arlo cameras, Nest thermostat, Shoji screens - but never assembled them into a coherent story about why this home is worth \$1,798,000 and what kind of life it makes possible. Buyers in this price range are comparison shoppers. They read listings carefully, and they respond to narrative clarity, not inventory lists. The view of Mount Diablo from the wrap-around deck is mentioned mid-paragraph. The lower-level in-law suite is framed as a footnote. The 0.73-acre lot and court privacy barely register. A buyer skimming that description doesn't come away with a clear picture of what makes 15 Surmont Ct different from every other five-bedroom in Lafayette. They move on.

* THE BRIGHTWORK DIFFERENCE

BrightWork's Zillow Showcase placement pairs a purpose-built narrative - written the way a great buyer's agent describes a home to a motivated client - with premium portal visibility that routes all buyer inquiries directly back to the listing team, not to a random third-party agent.

POSITIONING ANALYSIS

Metric	15 Surmont Ct	Lafayette Market Context
Price per Sq. Ft.	\$514/sqft	\$650–\$920/sqft (fixer range: \$650–\$720 renovated: \$780–\$840 premium: \$850–\$920)
Lot / Setting	0.73-acre private court lot, end-of-cul-de-sac, panoramic Mount Diablo views	Typical Lafayette lot: 0.25–0.40 acres, standard street-facing position
Architectural Character	1972 multi-level with open wood beam ceilings, Shoji screens, wrap-around deck, three fireplaces	Standard suburban split-level or ranch; character features uncommon at this square footage
Premium Features	Pool with sundeck, lighted sports court, firepit, 3-car garage with EV charger and workshop, self-contained lower-level suite	Pool and garage common at price point; sports court, workshop, and in-law suite are differentiators
HOA	None	No HOA typical for this area of Lafayette

The verdict: At \$514/sqft versus a benchmark range of \$650–\$920/sqft, this home sits near the lower end of that range. At \$514 per square foot, 15 Surmont Ct came to market at the low end of the Lafayette fixer range - a notable discount given the lot size, the view, the outdoor amenities, and the multi-level floor plan. The number was not the obstacle. The gap between what this home actually offers and what the marketing communicated is what held buyers back. A relaunch built around the view, the lot, and the lifestyle should close that gap quickly.

THE RELAUNCH STRATEGY: 3 PILLARS

We don't re-list this home. We relaunch it with new media, a narrative that finally does it justice, and distribution designed for the buyer it deserves.

Pillar I - Lead with the View, the Lot, and the Court Position

The single most important thing a relaunch of 15 Surmont Ct needs to do is make the Mount Diablo view and the 0.73-acre court setting the headline - not a supporting detail. Buyers who are willing to pay a premium for privacy, outdoor space, and a setting they can't find closer to downtown Lafayette need to understand immediately that this home has all three. That means purpose-built narrative, photography that captures the view from the deck, and a Sky Tour that shows the lot and the surrounding hillside in a way no ground photograph can.

Pillar II - Tell the In-Law Suite Story to the Right Buyers

The lower-level suite - bedroom, full bath, separate living areas - is a meaningful differentiator for a specific and growing segment of Lafayette buyers: multi-generational households, families with college-age children returning home, and buyers who want a dedicated home office or guest setup with real separation from the main living areas. That's a story worth telling directly and specifically, not burying at the end of a long listing description. A 3D Matterport tour lets those buyers walk the lower level from anywhere and understand exactly how it functions before they ever schedule a showing.

Pillar III - Reintroduce the Home with a Clean Start

After 62 days on the market, the stigma that accumulates around a stale listing is real - and it doesn't go away on its own. A relaunch of 15 Surmont Ct needs a full media rebuild: new photography, new narrative, and a distribution strategy that reaches buyers who were never exposed to the original listing. BrightWork's off-market private buyer list at offmarket.brightworkrealty.com gives us a way to reintroduce the home quietly to vetted, motivated buyers before it goes live again - so the public launch starts with momentum instead of from zero.

A DIFFERENT OPTION: THE QUIET LISTING

Sell Without the Disruption

A traditional listing puts a sign in your yard, opens your door to strangers every weekend, and puts your home's history on public record. For a home that already went through one listing cycle, there's a better starting point.

BrightWork maintains an active private buyer list through our off-market platform. These are Bay Area buyers who've opted in specifically to receive property alerts before anything hits Zillow. They're motivated, pre-qualified, and they believe an off-market home represents a real opportunity, which means they engage seriously.

- * **No public days on market.** The prior listing history stays private. A new buyer sees none of it.
- * **No sign, no open houses, no disruption.** The sale is a private conversation between a motivated buyer and a motivated seller.
- * **Option to go public anytime.** If the right off-market offer doesn't materialize in an agreed window, we transition directly into a full relaunch strategy with no time lost.

* HOW IT WORKS

We alert our private buyer list through offmarket.brightworkrealty.com - Bay Area buyers specifically seeking properties before they go public. If a serious match emerges within the agreed window, we negotiate and close privately. If not, we launch the full relaunch strategy immediately, with clean momentum and no days-on-market exposure.

TIMELINE: THE BRIGHTWORK SMART WAY

Phase 1 - Pre-Market Preparation (Weeks 1–2)

Staging, full media production, and a Coming Soon campaign - or a quiet listing launch to our private buyer network, depending on your preference.

Phase 2 - Strategic Launch (Week 3)

Thursday launch on Zillow Showcase with the full media package in premium placement. Targeted SF/Oakland digital ads go live the same day.

Phase 3 - Momentum Management (Weeks 4–5)

Active follow-up on every save, inquiry, and open house visitor. Final Offer gives serious buyers a transparent channel to submit competitive offers.

Phase 4 - The Close (Weeks 6–7)

We engineer competition, not just field offers. Our process keeps both sides of the transaction moving cleanly toward a close.

WHY BRIGHTWORK REALTY ADVOCATES

- * **Deep local roots:** 45+ years in Moraga, Lafayette, and Orinda. Ground-level knowledge of what buyers in each community are actually paying for.
- * **Premium marketing as a baseline:** Cinematic photography, floor plans, 3D tours, and Sky Tours on every listing. Not a luxury add-on.
- * **Portal dominance:** Zillow Showcase and homes.com premium placement. More views, enhanced listing pages, all leads to your team.
- * **Modern offer tools:** Final Offer gives buyers a transparent path to engage and gives you real-time demand data in one place.
- * **True advocacy:** We don't re-list homes. We forensically review what went wrong and rebuild the strategy from the ground up.

This home has real assets that the market never got to properly evaluate. That's a correctable problem. The window to correct it is still open.

Ready to talk? brightworkrealty.com · (925) 255-9727

Scan to see what a relaunch looks like for your home: relaunch.brightworkrealty.com

Important Notice

If you have entered into a listing agreement or active representation agreement with a licensed real estate agent in connection with this property, please disregard this mailing.

BrightWork Realty Advocates is a licensed real estate team operated by Ben Olsen, REALTOR, California DRE License #01409268. This communication is not intended to solicit properties currently listed for sale or under active representation.

The market analysis and strategic observations contained in this report are based on publicly available listing data and BrightWork's professional assessment of market conditions. They are not a formal appraisal and should not be relied upon as a certified valuation.

All property data referenced in this report was obtained from public records and MLS history. BrightWork Realty Advocates makes no warranty as to the accuracy of third-party data sources.

brightworkrealty.com · (925) 255-9727 · 455 Moraga Road, Suite I, Moraga, CA 94556



DIRECT
(925) 255-9727

EMAIL
ben@brightworkrealty.com

WEB
brightworkrealty.com

OFFICE
455 Moraga Road, Suite I
Moraga, CA 94556

THE BRIGHTWORK ADVANTAGE

- Buy Before You Sell
- BrightFlip Pre-Sale Improvements
- Final Offer Platform
- Zillow Showcase + homes.com Premium
- Off-Market Network
- Built to Close Clean

YOUR LISTING ADVISOR

Ben Olsen

Founding Partner | REALTOR · BrightWork Realty Advocates · DRE# 02014153

Ben founded BrightWork on a specific premise: the best outcomes are built before a home ever lists. With twenty years serving the East Bay's most competitive submarkets, he's developed a clear point of view on what separates a sale that closes well from one that doesn't, and the preparation, marketing, and negotiation strategy to act on it.

He entered the workforce at 14 in construction, a background that shapes how he thinks about pre-sale decisions, disclosure strategy, and what buyers actually scrutinize at inspection. That's a different lens than most agents carry into a listing consultation.

His approach to marketing is built on the same logic. Every campaign is designed for your home's specific buyer, not the average buyer. Portal strategy, campaign integration, and buyer targeting aren't add-ons at BrightWork. They're the baseline. Pre-sale prep, real fixes, and full disclosure before the home lists. The preparation is the negotiation.

20+

YEARS SERVING
LAMORINDA

\$1B+

PROPERTIES
SOLD

1,000+

BUYERS &
SELLERS

WHY HE SENT YOU THIS PACKET

When a listing expires, Ben reviews it. Not to pitch you, but because after enough of them, the pattern of what goes wrong becomes clear. If you received this analysis, he looked at your specific property and has a specific point of view about what happened. That's the conversation he's offering. No listing agreement on the table. Just a review. He'll also walk you through programs that turn seller constraints into options, and show you what a transaction designed to get everyone to the closing table feeling good actually looks like.

Why BrightWork Realty Advocates

Rooted in Lamorinda since 1977. BrightWork is built on the premise that the best outcomes start before a home ever lists. An orchestrated campaign designed for your home's buyer, not the average buyer. Programs that turn seller constraints into options. Transactions designed so everyone gets to the closing table feeling good.

That's The Smart Way to Real Estate.

EIGHT REASONS SMART SELLERS CHOOSE BRIGHTWORK

01 Superior Presentation

Professional photography, floor plans, 3D tours, and Sky Tours on every listing. Not the luxury package. The baseline.

02 Premium Portal Presence

Zillow Showcase and premium homes.com membership. Higher view counts, better placement, and buyer inquiries that route to your listing team.

03 Integrated Campaigns

Every sign, mailer, and open house connects to a digital system. Curious neighbors become trackable leads.

04 Modern Offer Management

Real-time portal data guides pricing decisions. Final Offer platform for properties with strong multi-offer potential.

05 Financial Tools & Capital Programs

Capital to fund pre-sale improvements with no out-of-pocket cost until close. Plus programs that remove the timing trap entirely.

06 Off-Market Strategy

A private list of serious Bay Area buyers. Test demand quietly or gain early access before properties hit MLS.

07 Advocacy for Unsold Homes

When a home hasn't sold, we don't re-list at a lower price. We conduct a forensic review and relaunch with a rebuilt strategy.

08 Built to Close Clean

Pre-sale prep, real fixes, and full disclosure to every buyer before the house lists. He structures listings to attract the best first offers from a position no one can argue with. The preparation is the negotiation.

BrightWork has served Lamorinda since 1977. Over \$1 billion in local real estate sold.

Ben Olsen | (925) 255-9727 | ben@brightworkrealty.com | brightworkrealty.com

Not Every Home Needs a Public Launch.

For sellers who need privacy, flexibility, or a different kind of timing — BrightWork has a smarter first step.

Most agents know one approach: list on the MLS, hit the portals, hold open houses. That works for many homes. For sellers who need privacy, flexibility, or more control over timing, BrightWork offers a structured, documented private path to the right buyer — built on relationships in Lamorinda that go back to 1977.

OFF MARKET SELLING HAS ITS BENEFITS

Your Home, Your Timing, No Pressure

No days-on-market counter. No public record. No nosy neighbors. Your home stays entirely private until you choose otherwise, and if you do go public later, you start fresh, with a clean slate and zero wasted days behind you.

Buyers Who Are Actually Ready

BrightWork maintains a curated list of serious, pre-qualified Bay Area buyers who have asked to be notified about Lamorinda properties. They are not browsing Zillow. Every showing is by appointment, with someone who qualifies and is genuinely interested.

Real Feedback Before You Commit

An off-market phase gives you genuine buyer response before you decide whether to close privately or step into a full MLS campaign. Either way, you move forward with real data and momentum, not day-one guesswork.

BrightWork's network of private buyers and collaborative realtor relationships has served Lamorinda since 1977.

Over \$1 billion in local real estate sold.

Deep relationships in Moraga, Lafayette, and Orinda.

WHO THE PRIVATE PATH SERVES

The Privacy-First Seller

No public listings, no open houses, and no days-on-market counter visible to buyers and agents, for whatever reason, professional or personal.

The Seller Still Preparing

Test genuine demand while staging or repairs are still underway, without burning days on market before you are ready.

The Strategically Timed Seller

Your next move depends on how this one closes. Control the sequence rather than react to a public countdown clock.

The Seller Testing the Waters

Get real buyer feedback before committing to a full public launch — or decide you do not need one at all.

Your home. Your timeline. Your terms.

Ready to find out whether the private path is the right first step?

Ben Olsen | (925) 255-9727

ben@brightworkrealty.com | brightworkrealty.com